

# **The Boy Who Cried Wolf**

On the slope above a small village, a young shepherd spent each day watching a flock of sheep. The work was quiet. The sheep cropped grass, the clouds moved slowly, and the only sounds were bells, wind, and the boy's own thoughts. At first he enjoyed the freedom. After several long afternoons, however, the silence began to feel like a cage. He wished for something exciting to happen.

One day he ran down the hill, waving his arms and shouting, "Wolf! Wolf! Please help me!" The villagers dropped their tools and hurried up the path with sticks and stones. They expected to find a wild animal among the sheep, but there was no wolf at all. The boy laughed at their worried faces. A few villagers scolded him, yet he only smiled, pleased that the hill had become lively for a while.

A few days later, boredom returned. Remembering how quickly everyone had come, the boy cried out again. Once more the villagers rushed to his aid. Once more they found nothing. This time their faces were less frightened than angry. An old farmer told the boy that a warning was a promise: when someone heard it, they trusted it enough to leave their own work behind. The boy nodded, but he did not truly listen.

Near sunset one evening, a real wolf crept from the trees. It moved low through the grass, its eyes fixed on the sheep. The boy's throat tightened. He shouted louder than he had ever shouted before. "Wolf! Wolf! This time it is real!" The villagers heard him, but each remembered the two tricks. They stayed by their homes, thinking he wanted another laugh.

The wolf scattered the flock before the shepherd could drive it away. When the boy returned to the village with only a few sheep, he wept and tried to explain. The old farmer did not speak harshly. He simply said, "People may forgive a lie, but trust does not always return at once." From then on, the boy learned that words can be useful like a bell or a rope, but only when people know they can rely on them.